

ing possible topics for real world community meetings. Searching for a particular user can be restricted by what settings the user has specified in their control panel, or by an initial default setting for a site. For example, on Friendster, the default setting is that users who are over three degrees away from a particular person cannot see how they are connected to that person and cannot view their full profile (instead they can only see a reduced version of that person's profile). This can make searching for some users difficult, and some people must arrange outside the social network to make a connection manually within it.

3.3 Perceiving Other Users

Karma

A user's reputation can not only be affected by how they relate to other people in the real world, but also by how they conduct themselves in an online social network. Social networks often employ a variety of methods to allow users to add positively or negatively to another user's personal reputation or rating, thereby affecting how that user is perceived by the rest of the network. Rating another user can be carried out in a private or public manner. orkut is unique insofar that it offers people the chance to express how they feel about fellow friends and members through a rating system known as karma points. They are rated through a system of karma points whether people are thought of as sexy, cool or how trustworthy they are considered and by how much.

This is a good way for people to get feedback on other members creating an interest in members and in their social network and a curiosity as to who is rated amongst their friends so highly and the reasons why. Members can rate each friend individually based on how they perceive them making their profile more interesting with hearts, ice cubes and stars rating people and being a fan of individual members.

An endorsement or testimonial is another feature of social networking sites, where a fan or friend will declare exactly what it is that they find positive about another user. Most sites like Friendster or Tribe require that the user must approve the testi-